

Sales Training Debrief — Session 20

Count Deals, Not Bookings. Reset the Metric.

Sales training led by Corie Dawson, Director · Monday 1 June 2026 · Marketing Sweet

1. Stop counting bookings — count deals

The opening principle of the session. New reps come into the company and the initial focus is on bookings made per day. That's deliberate — phase one is proving the rep can pick up the phone. But once a rep is past that phase, counting bookings is no longer the right metric. Counting bookings becomes a vanity number that hides the real work, which is converting those bookings into deals — and the money those deals produce.

"You're not making calls. You're finding deals. Reframe the focus. What you're actually doing on the phone is making money."

The shift in practice:

- Track money per day, not bookings per day.
- Reverse-engineer from a daily revenue target back to deals — and only then to bookings.
- Treat bookings as the means, not the end. The booking is a step toward the deal — never the goal.
- A rep with 5 bookings and 2 deals beats a rep with 10 bookings and 1 deal — every time.

2. Reverse-engineer from the money

The mechanical exercise the session walked through. Pick a daily income target. Divide by the commission per deal. That gives you the number of deals required. From there, work out how many bookings are needed — but only the right kind.

The maths in action:

1. Set a daily income target. Example: \$250/day.
2. Divide by commission per deal. Example: \$125/deal → 2 deals/day.
3. Start at the minimum number of bookings the rep believes can convert. Example: 2 strong bookings.
4. Add the insurance policy — extra bookings as backup.

THE WIN CONDITION Hit the daily income target with the fewest bookings necessary. That's a focused rep. That's not a calls-per-day rep — that's a deals-per-day rep.

3. The insurance policy mindset

A specific structural reframe for how to think about daily bookings. Rather than aiming for 7-10 bookings as the primary number, start at the minimum required for the income target — then add extra bookings as insurance against attrition. Each layer of insurance has a name and a purpose.

LAYER	PURPOSE
TWO BOOKINGS	The core — what you need if your conversion is what you believe it is.
+ TWO MORE	Third-party-only insurance. Covers you if one of the core two falls out.
+ TWO MORE	Comprehensive insurance. Covers a bad day where the conversion drops.
TOTAL: 6 STRONG BOOKINGS	Six well-prepared bookings beats twenty shallow ones. Every time.

"You're not chasing 20 bookings. You're chasing two deals — and you're laying down insurance policies behind them in case the maths is wrong."

4. History is history — don't let it set your ceiling

A reframe that pushes back against "that's not realistic" thinking. Reps default to extrapolating from their past conversion rates. If they've historically needed 7 bookings to get 2 deals, they assume that ratio is fixed. The session pushed back hard: history is what was true under old conditions. New conditions — better prep, sharper pitches, the techniques being trained — produce new ratios.

"History is history. If you don't like your history, change. You don't have to be the rep who needed seven bookings per deal — you can be the rep who needs two. Be a different human being."

How to break the history ceiling:

- Question every "that's how it usually works" thought. The usual is what produced the current result.
- Aim for a ratio that's better than your history. If it doesn't work, you've still aimed up — and learned where the real ratio is.
- Track each pitch as a separate experiment. Don't average across a week — diagnose each one.
- If a deal drops, ask which technique was missing — not "that's just normal attrition."

5. Phase one vs phase two thinking

The mental model at the centre of the session. Most communication and decision-making happens in "phase one" — automatic, reactive, default responses. "How are you?" → "I'm good." "Is this deal going to close?" → "Yeah, it's a great deal." Phase one is the autopilot. Phase two is the considered version — the rep actually stops, thinks, and gives a real answer.

PHASE ONE · AUTOPILOT	PHASE TWO · CONSIDERED
"How are you?" → "I'm good."	"How are you?" → "Honestly, it's been a rough morning — here's why..."
"Is this deal going to close?" → "Yes, it's hot."	"Is this deal going to close?" → Pause. Run through the actual signals.
"Did the buyer say yes to process and company?" → "I think so."	Did the buyer explicitly confirm? Or did the rep skip that step?
Most communication, most days	What strong reps train themselves to do on the moments that matter

"You ask me how I am, I'll tell you literally how I am. That's a phase two response. Most people's whole conversational life is phase one. The buyer who's saying yes might be in phase one too — and that yes might not survive into tomorrow."

6. Pressure-testing — surfacing phase two answers

A technique the session called "gun to the head" — a deliberately stark framing designed to shock the rep out of phase one autopilot and into phase two thinking. The technique is not about literal stakes; it's about asking yourself a question with the assumption that there are real consequences, which sharpens awareness rapidly.

How to apply it:

- Before submitting a forecast: pause. "If my whole next quarter depended on this prediction, would I still say what I just said?"
- Before logging a deal as likely-to-close: "Would I bet my own money on this one?"
- Before walking away from a stalled deal: "If I had to recover this in 24 hours, what would I do?"
- Before responding to a buyer's pushback: "What's the real question they're asking?"

The technique applied to relationships, decisions, and self-talk works the same way. Pretend the stakes are extreme. The pretend-stakes pull the brain into phase two thinking — where the real answer is.

7. Awareness — the highest-leverage skill

The closing principle of the session. Awareness is the ability to see yourself, your situation, and your interactions from outside — to step out of phase one autopilot and observe what's actually happening. It's the skill underneath everything else. Without it, even the best technique runs blind.

"Awareness is the ultimate gift. It lets you crawl behind the eyes of everyone you're selling to — and see yourself from their angle. Once you can see what they're seeing, the sale is no longer manipulation. It's giving them what they need."

How awareness compounds:

- Awareness in pitches: hearing what the buyer actually said, not what you expected them to say.
- Awareness in delivery: catching the wrong tone in your own voice before the buyer reacts to it.
- Awareness in pipeline: noticing which deals are autopilot-yes versus considered-yes.
- Awareness in self-management: noticing when you're operating on autopilot — and choosing to step into phase two.

8. The brain as calculator — the soul as the driver

A mental model for how to direct your own attention and effort. Treat your brain like a calculator — it does what it's told, and it filters for what you give it. The soul (or whatever you want to call the deliberate, intentional part of you) is the one giving the inputs. If you tell the calculator "find me silver Corollas," you'll start seeing them everywhere. If you tell it "find me deals," you'll start seeing them too.

Applied to sales:

- Give the brain a specific target — two deals at \$125 each = \$250 today.
- The brain's filtering mechanism will start surfacing opportunities you'd otherwise miss.
- Vision boards work for the same reason. They give the calculator specific inputs.
- Vague goals ("do better") give the calculator nothing to filter for.

9. Frame the day — find real wins, not fake positivity

The session closed on framing. End every day by identifying real wins — not by faking positivity. The rep who looks at a day where they made one deal and goes "it was a great day" without evidence is faking. The rep who looks at the same day and notices "the deal that closed used technique X, and that worked" is finding real wins. Real wins compound; fake positivity decays.

The framing discipline:

- Find the real silver lining. Not generic positivity — specific evidence.
- "The glass is full" — half water, half air. Both count.
- Hard days produce hard lessons. The win is the lesson, not the deal count.
- If you're struggling to find a real win, the frame is wrong — not the day.

10. Action items this week

9. Pick a daily income target. Reverse-engineer it back to deals required, then bookings required (minimum + insurance).
10. Catch yourself in phase one this week. When you notice an autopilot answer, stop and re-answer in phase two.
11. Run the pressure test on at least three pipeline deals: "would I bet my own money on this one?"
12. Build a small vision board. Specific items. Pin it where you can see it daily.

13. At the end of every day, write down one real win — with specific evidence. Not generic positivity.
14. Stop counting bookings as the headline number. Track money and deals instead.

THE ONE-LINER Count deals, not bookings. Reverse-engineer from the money. Phase two on the moments that matter. Find the real win every day.